

chants and hallucinogens. The most effective intermediaries were members of the royal family. They were considered to be already semi-divine and able to call on the gods to favor their cities.

Appeasing the gods with blood

The Maya believed that humankind owed the gods a debt for their creation and that sacrifices acted as a form of repayment. The most powerful offering of all was blood. It could be that of war captives, who were decapitated on temple steps. Even better, the king himself cut his own flesh with sting-ray spines, and the drops of blood were caught on ritual paper and burned. Inhaling the smoke was believed to open up visions of the spirit world.

Such sacrifices were hoped to cure illnesses. For the Maya, damage to one of the several souls that each person was believed to possess caused disease. One soul was the *o'ohlis*—the spark embedded into all things by the creator god. Another was the *way ob*, the animal companion that shared every person's soul. Kings shared their souls with jaguars but were not restricted to one *way ob*: royalty and other magic-rich figures such as priests could have up to 13.

Telling the future

Time, place, and divinity were interwoven with a complex system of numbers, colors, and points of the compass. For the Maya, heaven had 13 layers above the earth. The underworld, where most souls ended up after death, was said to have nine, and each god four manifestations dependent on colors and cardinal directions. The Mayan year had a ritual calendar of 260 days and a secular one of 365 days, which coincided once each “calendar round” of 52 years.

Mayan priests were the guardians of the knowledge necessary to navigate this system. They compiled horoscopes and almanacs, making careful observations of heavenly bodies such as Venus and the moon. From their studies, they determined the auspicious days on which actions should be carried out. They also interpreted omens derived from the entrails of sacrificial animals or the patterns of grain thrown on to a surface, or looked for visions in a magical mirror. In a world where magic and the gods were ever-present, the need for the Maya to understand divine messages was all the more compelling.

◀ Madrid codex

Most Mayan books were destroyed after the Spanish conquest. The Madrid codex, one of the few survivors, contains almanacs and calendrical guides to assist Mayan priests in the performance of rituals.



▲ Ritual bloodletting

This frieze shows Shield Jaguar II, king of the Mayan city of Yaxchilan from 681 to 742, holding a flaming torch over his wife, Lady K'abal Xook. She pierces her tongue with a thorn-studded rope in an act of blood sacrifice.

